

The First Term Survival Pack

Where the marks actually are, what each mark scheme actually rewards, and the twenty per cent of the A-level that is arithmetic. Eight pages, and every fact in it comes from a board document you can open.

This is the pack for the person who is teaching Year 12 Economics this term and has not had time to read two specifications end to end. It is not a scheme of work and it is not revision material. It is the small set of things that change how you mark and what you drill in the first half term.

Where every fact here comes from

Read out of AQA's specification for 7135 and 7136 version 1.3, AQA's published mark scheme for A-level Economics 7136 Paper 1 June 2023, and Pearson's Getting Started guide for GCE Economics A. The document is named beside each claim and the links are on page 8.

Where this pack says something AQA or Pearson does not say, it is labelled **OUR VIEW**. Where a figure is invented for an exercise, it says so.

What is inside

Page 2	Both courses on one page. Papers, marks, time, weighting.
Page 3	Where the marks sit. A real AQA paper, question by question.
Page 4	The grid nobody reads. AQA's fifteen mark question rewards no evaluation.
Page 5	Edexcel's three extended response commands, in Pearson's own words.
Page 6	The twenty per cent that is arithmetic, and the nine skills behind it.
Page 7	A nine question baseline test for week one, with answers.
Page 8	A first half term checklist, and how to check this pack yourself.

The whole pack in four lines

- On AQA, half of Paper 1 sits on two questions worth 25 marks each.
- AQA's 15 mark grid never mentions evaluation. Its 25 mark grid wants it throughout, not at the end.
- Pearson names three extended response commands and attaches no mark tariffs to them.
- Both boards guarantee that at least a fifth of the A-level is quantitative, and interpreting a chart counts.

Currency, since it is the first thing to go wrong. AQA 7136 and Edexcel 9EC0 are both unchanged for a course starting in September 2026. Nothing in this pack is written to a specification that is being withdrawn.

AQA A-level Economics 7136

PAPER	CONTENT	FORMAT	SECTIONS
1 Markets and market failure	Content 1 to 8	2 hours 80 marks 33.3%	A data response, choice of one context from two, 40 marks. B essays, choice of one from three, 40 marks.
2 National and international economy	Content 9 to 14	2 hours 80 marks 33.3%	The same structure as Paper 1.
3 Economic principles and issues	All content 1 to 14	2 hours 80 marks 33.3%	A multiple choice, 30 marks. B case study, 50 marks.
Total scaled mark	240	All compulsory	Choice sits inside Papers 1 and 2.

Pearson Edexcel A level Economics A, 9EC0

PAPER	CONTENT	FORMAT	SECTIONS
1 Markets and business behaviour	Themes 1 and 3	2 hours 100 marks 35%	A multiple choice and short answer, all questions. B one data response in parts. C one extended response, one from two.
2 The national and global economy	Themes 2 and 4	2 hours 100 marks 35%	The same structure as Paper 1.
3 Microeconomics and macroeconomics	All themes	2 hours 100 marks 30%	Two stimulus based data response questions, each in parts, each containing one extended open response chosen from two.
Total	300 marks	All compulsory	Themes: 1 markets and market failure, 2 the UK economy, 3 business behaviour and the labour market, 4 a global perspective.

The structural difference. AQA splits micro and macro across Papers 1 and 2 and reunites them in Paper 3. Edexcel pairs a first year theme with a second year theme in both, so a student cannot finish Theme 1 and file it away. Both boards publish AO weightings as ranges, so an exact per cent is somebody's estimate.

AQA assessment objective weightings, A-level

	AO1	AO2	AO3	AO4
Papers 1 and 2, approx %	5 to 8	7 to 10	9 to 11	7 to 10
Paper 3, approx %	7 to 10	9 to 12	6 to 9	5 to 8
Overall, approx %	20 to 23	26 to 29	26 to 29	22 to 25

Where to look. AQA specification, section 2 and section 5.3. Pearson, Getting Started guide, section 5.3.

A real AQA paper, question by question

Specifications describe papers in the abstract. This is what one actually looked like. Every row is read off AQA's published mark scheme for A-level Economics 7136 Paper 1, June 2023.

Section A, data response. Students choose one context from two, and each context is worth 40 marks

Q	MARKS	COMMAND	WHAT THE QUESTION ACTUALLY ASKED
01	2	Calculate	Calculate an index number from a table, answer to two decimal places
02	4	Explain	Explain how the data show a stated relationship
03	9	Explain, with a diagram	With the help of a diagram, explain why an activity might lead to market failure
04	25	Evaluate	Evaluate policies that could be used to achieve a stated outcome
40		AQA prints "Total for this context: 40 marks" under the fourth question	

Section B, essays. Students choose one essay from three, and each essay is worth 40 marks

PART	MARKS	COMMAND IN JUNE 2023
first part	15	Explain, in all three essays
second part	25	Assess in essay 1, Evaluate in essay 2, Discuss in essay 3
40		AQA prints "Total for this essay: 40 marks"

Read the two tables together

On this paper, **50 of the 80 marks** sat on the two questions worth 25 each. A further 30 sat on everything else combined. A student who is fluent on the small questions and vague on the 25s is capping themselves well before the boundary. The two mark question was a calculation and the nine mark question required a diagram. Neither is optional and neither can be revised the night before.

One series is one series. AQA does not guarantee the same commands next year, and the 25 mark questions in June 2023 used three different words. What the specification fixes is the section structure and the 40 plus 40 split, on page 2.

What to do with this in the first half term OUR VIEW

- **Set a 25 before October.** If half the paper sits on one question type, waiting until spring to write one is a strange way to spend the autumn.
- **Teach the diagram as part of the answer.** The nine mark question asked for one in the stem, so an explanation without a diagram loses marks before the marker reaches the argument.

Where to look. AQA mark scheme, A-level Economics 7136/1, June 2023, on filestore.aqa.org.uk. The tariffs are printed in square brackets after each question stem.

AQA's fifteen mark question rewards no evaluation

AQA publishes two levels of response grids, one for every 25 mark question and one for every 15 mark question. They are not the same grid at different lengths.

The 25 mark grid, level 5, 21 to 25 marks

Sound, focused analysis and well-supported evaluation that: is well organised, showing sound knowledge and understanding of economic terminology, concepts and principles with few, if any, errors; includes good application of relevant economic principles to the given context and, where appropriate, good use of data to support the response; includes well-focused analysis with clear, logical chains of reasoning; **includes supported evaluation throughout the response and in a final conclusion.**

AQA mark scheme, 7136/1, June 2023. Five levels: 1 to 5, 6 to 10, 11 to 15, 16 to 20, 21 to 25.

The 15 mark grid, level 3, 11 to 15 marks

A good response provides an answer that: is well organised and develops a selection of the key issues that are relevant to the question; shows sound knowledge and understanding of economic terminology, concepts and principles with few, if any, errors; includes good application of relevant economic principles to the given context and, where appropriate, good use of data to support the response; **includes well-focused analysis with clear, logical chains of reasoning.**

AQA mark scheme, 7136/1, June 2023. Three levels: 1 to 5, 6 to 10, 11 to 15.

The sentence stops at analysis

The word evaluation does not appear anywhere in the 15 mark grid, at any of its three levels. A student who spends their last four minutes weighing up the argument on a 15 mark question is doing careful, intelligent work for zero marks, and the marker cannot give it to them. The other half of the same point: on the 25, evaluation is not a paragraph at the end. AQA asks for it **throughout the response and in a final conclusion.**

The band below, so the difference is visible

25 mark grid, level 4, 16 to 20 marks. Sound, focused analysis and **some supported evaluation** that: is well organised, showing sound knowledge and understanding with few, if any, errors; includes some good application of relevant economic principles to the given context; includes some well-focused analysis with clear, logical chains of reasoning; **includes some reasonable, supported evaluation.**

AQA mark scheme, 7136/1, June 2023

Level 4 and level 5 use the same words for knowledge, application and analysis. The only thing that moves is evaluation: *some reasonable, supported* becomes *throughout the response and in a final conclusion*. That one line separates the 16 to 20 band from the 21 to 25 band.

OUR VIEW

Teach the two as different tasks with different endings, from the first essay you set. Give students both grids on one side of A4. And when you mark a 25, count how many paragraphs carried evaluation, not whether the last one did.

Check this in two minutes. Open the 7136/1 June 2023 mark scheme. The 25 mark grid is printed at the start of Section A, the 15 mark grid at the start of Section B, each with a line telling you which questions it applies to.

Edexcel's three extended response commands

Pearson prints a taxonomy table for 9ECO giving what each command requires. This is that table, word for word. The differences between the three rows are small, deliberate and easy to miss, so they are picked out in bold.

COMMAND	WHAT PEARSON SAYS IT REQUIRES
Assess	Accurate knowledge and understanding; apply to context and/or use relevant examples; use of economic theory applied appropriately; and evaluation which is supported by chains of reasoning, in context and balanced .
Discuss	Accurate knowledge and understanding; apply to context and/or use relevant examples; use of economic theory applied appropriately; logical chains of reasoning ; and evaluation which is supported by relevant reasoning, in context and balanced .
To what extent / Evaluate	Accurate knowledge and understanding; apply to context and/or use relevant examples; evidence fully and reliably integrated ; use of economic theory applied appropriately; logical and coherent chains of reasoning; and evaluation which is supported by chains of reasoning, in context, with critical awareness and informed judgements .

Pearson groups To what extent and Evaluate as a single row. They are one command with two wordings, not two commands.

Two things this table does not say

It gives no mark tariffs. Nothing in the Getting Started guide attaches a number of marks to Assess or to Discuss. If you have seen a poster that says "Assess is 12 marks", that number came from somewhere else and you should find out where before a class learns it.

It is not a hierarchy. Pearson presents three commands with three requirement lists. It does not say that To what extent is harder than Assess. It does ask for more in that row, which is a fact about the wording, and the two are not the same statement.

The phrase both boards share

AQA's grids ask for "clear, logical chains of reasoning". Pearson's table asks for "logical chains of reasoning" and, at the top, "logical and coherent chains of reasoning". Whichever board you teach, the same sentence structure earns the marks: a cause, the mechanism that connects it to an effect, and the effect, with no step missing.

The step students skip is almost always the middle one. "Interest rates rise, so investment falls" has the cause and the effect and nothing between them. "Interest rates rise, so the cost of borrowing to fund a project rises, so fewer projects clear the firm's expected rate of return, so planned investment falls" is the same idea with the mechanism visible. That is what a chain of reasoning is.

Where to look. Pearson, Getting Started guide for GCE Economics A 2015, section 5.5, Taxonomy (command words). Section 5.4 covers the question types and section 5.6 the mark schemes.

A fifth of the A-level is arithmetic, on both boards

The assessment of quantitative skills will include at least Level 2 mathematical skills as a minimum of 20% of the overall A-level marks.

AQA 7135 and 7136 specification, annex 7.2

Quantitative skills will be assessed in each exam series, with a minimum of 20% of the total marks across the A level.

Pearson, Getting Started guide, section 6.1

Two boards, two documents, the same floor. On AQA that is at least 48 of the 240 marks. On Edexcel, at least 60 of the 300. It is not a strand you can leave to the maths department and it is not concentrated in one paper.

AQA's nine quantitative skills, word for word

#	SKILL
1	calculate, use and understand ratios and fractions
2	calculate, use and understand percentages and percentage changes
3	understand and use the terms mean, median and relevant quantiles
4	construct and interpret a range of standard graphical forms
5	calculate and interpret index numbers
6	calculate cost, revenue and profit (marginal, average, totals)
7	make calculations to convert from money to real terms
8	make calculations of elasticity and interpret the result
9	interpret, apply and analyse information in written, graphical and numerical forms

The AS list is the same nine with two differences: it says mean and median without quantiles, and average and total cost without marginal. The AS minimum is 15%, not 20%.

Read skill 9 again

Interpreting information is on the quantitative list. So a question that gives a student a chart and asks what it shows is a quantitative question even though nothing is calculated. That is why the 20% is easier to reach than it looks, and why students who say they are "not doing the maths bit" have misunderstood which bit they are refusing.

Nine questions, one per skill

Written by us, not by a board, in the order of AQA's list on page 6. Every figure is invented for the exercise. Twenty minutes, week one, to find out which of the nine is missing before it matters.

QUESTION

- 1 A firm splits output between two plants in the ratio 3:5. Total output is 4,800 units. How many units come from the larger plant?
- 2 A price rises from £2.40 to £2.61. What is the percentage change, to one decimal place?
- 3 Five workers earn £310, £290, £470, £305 and £300 a week. Give the mean and the median. Which better describes this group?
- 4 A real GDP index reads 100 in 2020, 104.2 in 2021 and 101.9 in 2022. Sketch it as a line chart and say what happened to real GDP in 2022.
- 5 Sales were 1.25 million units in the base year and 1.41 million this year. Give this year's index number to two decimal places.
- 6 A firm makes 200 units. Total cost £3,600, selling price £26. Give total revenue, profit and average cost. The 201st unit would take total cost to £3,617. Make it?
- 7 A worker earned £520 a week in 2024 and £546 in 2026. The price index was 100 in 2024 and 107 in 2026. What is the 2026 wage in 2024 prices, and is the worker better off?
- 8 Price falls from £5.00 to £4.50 and quantity demanded rises from 800 to 920. Calculate price elasticity of demand. What should happen to total revenue, and does it?
- 9 The unemployment rate was 4.1% in 2024 and 4.4% in 2026. A student writes "unemployment rose by 0.3%". Correct them in one sentence.

Answers

- 1 3,000 units. 5 of the 8 parts, so $4,800 \times \frac{5}{8}$.
- 2 A rise of 8.8%. 0.21 divided by 2.40 is 8.75%.
- 3 Mean £335, median £305. The median, because the £470 pulls the mean above four of the five workers.
- 4 It fell, by about 2.2%. Watch for "it fell by 2.3", which subtracts index points instead of dividing by 104.2.
- 5 112.80. 1.41 divided by 1.25 , times 100.
- 6 Revenue £5,200, profit £1,600, average cost £18. Yes: the extra unit costs £17 and earns £26.
- 7 £510.28 in 2024 prices, so no. Wages rose 5%, prices 7%, real wage down about 1.9%.
- 8 Quantity up 15%, price down 10%, so PED is minus 1.5, elastic. Revenue rises: £4,000 becomes £4,140.
- 9 It rose by 0.3 percentage *points*. As a share of the original rate that is a rise of about 7.3%.

Marking it. Question 9 is the one worth reading first. A student who holds percentage points apart from per cent will not lose data response marks all year.

First half term checklist

- ☐ Run the nine question baseline in week one and record which of the nine skills the class is missing.
- ☐ Give every student both AQA grids, or Pearson's taxonomy table, on one side of A4 in the first fortnight.
- ☐ Set your first 15 mark question and your first 25 mark question in the same half term, so the difference is felt and not just described.
- ☐ Say out loud, more than once, that evaluation earns nothing on a 15 and everything on a 25.
- ☐ Put a calculation into every data response you set, however small. The twenty per cent is a floor, not a topic.
- ☐ Teach one diagram to fluency before you teach five to recognition.
- ☐ Check that your department's command word poster matches your board. AQA's grids and Pearson's taxonomy are not interchangeable.
- ☐ Read one published mark scheme yourself before you write your own.

Check this pack yourself

WHAT TO CHECK	WHERE
AQA paper structures, AO weightings, the nine quantitative skills, the 20% minimum	AQA AS and A-level Economics 7135, 7136 specification, version 1.3. filestore.aqa.org.uk , Economics, specifications
The June 2023 tariffs and both levels of response grids	AQA mark scheme, A-level Economics 7136/1, June 2023. filestore.aqa.org.uk , sample papers and mark schemes, 2023, June
Edexcel paper structures, the command word table, the 20% minimum	Pearson, Getting Started guide, GCE Economics A 2015. qualifications.pearson.com , A level, Economics A

One thing this pack does not claim

You may have seen a list of ten AQA Economics command words. AQA's own page for that list returns an error, and no AQA PDF we opened carries one. So this pack quotes the commands that appear on a real paper and in the published grids, and does not print a list. If AQA publishes one, we will add it and say where it came from.

That is the standard for everything here. A claim with no document behind it is not a claim we make, even when we are fairly sure it is right. Being unsure and saying so costs a teacher nothing. Being confident and wrong costs them a lesson.

Also free for A-level Economics: the Diagram Bank, the Data Response Decoder, and a first half term of Do Now starters. All at thebusiness.school/resources, no sign up. Made something that works? Put it on the same shelf at thebusiness.school/resources/share.